Walking with Rahul Gandhi: Bridging Hearts and the Nation

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Yatras have been of great importance across the world since ancient times. Whether it was the journey of Jesus Christ, of Prophet Muhammad from Mecca to Medina known as Hijrah, the journey of Mahavir Swami, Rama's forest journey, the journey of Tathagat (the Buddha), Mahatma Gandhi's Dandi March or other such yatras, I always felt that had I been there at the time of these historic movements, I would have definitely participated in them.

I am a wanderer at heart and travelling is my passion. So when I learnt about Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra, my instant thought was that this would be a remarkable initiative and he would receive immense support and love from the people. I also felt that this Yatra would provide an opportunity to the people to understand the real Rahul Gandhi. I was excited and started taking an interest in civil society discussions about the same. But when I received an invitation to participate in it, I was overjoyed. I shared this news with my colleagues, and they had numerous questions regarding the purpose, significance and potential outcomes of the Yatra. To many of their queries, my response was this: In this nation, there is immense reverence for yatras, and when someone leaves behind their comfort and ventures out on the road, people's affection and respect for them knows no bounds.

However, many of our friends from civil society and the Dalit movement also expressed concerns that this Yatra was being led by a prominent leader and the former national president of a political party. They suggested that individuals from the social sector, such as I, should refrain from participating to maintain our apolitical image. I welcomed these suggestions